



Camera? Smartphone?

A glimpse into the future of the camera-phone with Artefact's Wireless Viewfinder Interchangeable Lens camera. Check out the concept at <http://bit.ly/vc3tIK>

Point-and-shoot cameras test

The Creative ART filters are quite impressive, especially the Grainy Film and Dramatic Tone.

The panorama mode offers options such as manual, auto and assisted stitching. In the Auto mode, you press the shutter once and then after you follow the path to a target marker. On reaching it the camera releases the shutter. It then gets working at stitching the photos which takes quite a while. A nifty little feature.

Performance

In the low light test, the Nikon P300 gave a decent output in the Auto mode as well as at ISO 400, whereas the P7100 tended to give a very vivid image with a decent amount of sharpness. The Canon S100 had a very balanced output at ISO 400 but its low light preset mode wasn't that great as it tended to blur the details of our test subject, thanks to the ISO shooting upto 6400. Same was the case with the IXUS 310HS where the photographs at ISO 400 were better than its low light preset mode. The Olympus XZ1 gave slightly darker images in the Auto mode, but its preset modes were better.

In the High ISO tests, we noticed that the Canon S100's output at ISO 1600 was comparable to the output from the Nikon P7100 and Olympus XZ-1 at ISO 800. We got really good images with the S100 at

ISO 1600 and usable ones at ISO 3200, but with prominent noise at 100 percent crops. At lower ISOs all cameras gave sharp images.

In the sharpness and detail test shot the Canon S100, IXUS 310HS and Nikon P7100 gave a brilliant performance with every strand of the thread visible perfectly, including the black and dark brown threads, where it is difficult to separate out the threads. Even the IC numbers on the soundcard were clearly legible. The Nikon P300 lost detail at ISO 400 when compared with the S100 and the P7100. The Olympus XZ1 had an issue with focussing at the set distance so we had to move it further behind. XZ1 also gave sharp images but detailing was not in the same league as the S100 or P7100.

In the macro test, we noticed a slight bit of distortion in the P7100 but pixel clarity of the image was largely intact whereas in the S100 there was no distortion but pixel clarity was not as good as the P7100.

For flash tests, the P300 was better than the rest at giving a well lit image, with the laptop screen being quite legible. The Canon S100 was the next best but there was prominent vignetting. The P7100 also gave a good flash output with well lit scene and a legible laptop screen. The flash on the IXUS 310HS was not as powerful, though.

Chromatic aberration was non-existent upto 100 per cent, barely visible at 400 per cent for the Canon S100. Even the P7100 did not have any visible fringing. With the P300 at the telephoto end, we noticed blotchy details, but no visible fringing as such. On the IXUS 310HS chromatic aberration was visible at 100 per cent crop.

While shooting with the Nikon P7100 outdoors, we found that the horizontal panning is jerky when shot while holding the camera in the hand. Zooming is smooth. Outdoors, it focuses much better than indoors, as in there is no hunting for focus for an endless amount of time. With the Olympus XZ-1, noise suppression and focussing while zooming was an issue. Unwanted reflections from the fluorescent lights were prominent. In outdoor shooting, details were not that great and we noticed a slight bit of barrel distortion at the edges.

With the Nikon P300 panning was shaky, but better than the P7100. Zooming while shooting isn't advisable, though.

The Canon S100 was much better than the competing cameras. Focussing wasn't an issue even while zooming onto the subject. Colours and details were quite good. With the IXUS 310HS we noticed that the overall video quality was decent, but the zoom dial has a pointy edge which is annoying

to use and the zoom mechanism is also very slow when compared to other cameras.

Verdict

Thanks to its great image quality and video performance, the Canon Powershot S100 won the Best Performer award. This is the best high end compact in the market today with excellent low light performance. You will never fall short of any features including the battery sipping GPS. The Best Buy award went to Nikon's flagship Performance series camera, the P7100, as that was the next best camera after the S100 in this category. Also its pricing was quite good.

Travel Zooms

Some years ago the maximum zoom you could expect on your point and shoot cameras (not the ultra zooms) was 5x – 8x. The need for more optical zoom in compact form factors led to this category of cameras called Travel Zooms.

Features and Design

Canon had two cameras – SX 220HS and SX 230HS – in this segment which are similar in most aspects. The SX 230HS has a GPS receiver and it supports "Eye-Fi" cards whereas the SX 220HS does not. Both have a similar build quality – plastic body, good grip despite the presence of a mode dial in the place of a thumb rest. Below



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